CONNECT DAILY

Monday 26 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- A quiet weekend for big policy moves, but the row over Ofsted's leadership rumbled on and ministers issued fresh pay-reform instructions.
- Lucy Powell twice declined on Sky News to back chief inspector Sir Martyn Oliver by name; her spokesperson later said she does have confidence in him.
- Powell has separately asked the pay review body to consider scrapping the headteacher pay ceiling entirely.
- Locally, Sheffield has joined a new regional taskforce on NEET young people, and schools are on half term all week.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

27 Oct 2026 — South Yorkshire Mayoral Combined Authority Board meets.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot over pay, funding and workload closes.

OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

- **Powell under fire over Ofsted confidence row.** Pressed repeatedly on Sky News on whether she backed chief inspector Sir Martyn Oliver, Lucy Powell said only that she had "confidence in Ofsted", prompting accusations from the Conservatives of a leadership failure. A spokesperson later said she does have confidence in Oliver personally - several unions have issued no-confidence votes over the report-card inspection model. (Schools Week)

WORKFORCE & FUNDING

- **Leadership pay ceiling could be scrapped.** Powell has asked the School Teachers' Review Body to assess removing the cap on headteacher pay entirely, extending existing pay flexibilities to deputy and assistant heads, and how new minimum pay floors should apply to academies under the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act. NAHT called the remit too narrow to tackle the real pressures on leaders. (Schools Week)
- **RAAC rebuilds barely moving.** Work has yet to start at nearly all of the roughly 100 schools with high-risk RAAC concrete that were promised a full rebuild, with more than half of projects still not out to tender, Schools Week reports - despite the scheme now running for several years. (Schools Week)

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Sheffield joins national NEET taskforce.** The city is one of 13 Yorkshire and Humber councils joining the Government's new NEET Taskforce after recording 788 16-17 year-olds not in education, employment or training in 2025 - a 7.7% rate, the 11th-highest in England. Sheffield College is doubling places on its King's Trust programme for NEETs to 180. (The Star)

JARGON-BUSTER · STRB

Today's funding story centres on the pay body ministers just gave fresh instructions to.

The School Teachers' Review Body (STRB) is the independent panel that recommends annual pay and conditions for teachers and school leaders in England. Each year the Education Secretary sets its "remit" - what it's asked to look at. Ministers aren't bound to accept its recommendations, but usually do, in large part.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.